Western Avenue BRT:
Building the Coalition it Needs.



Prepared for the Chicago Transit Authority
By Sujan Kakumanu

Note: Fictional Premise.
Prepared for CPLN 6540 - Spring 2026.
University of Pennsylvania Weitzman School of Design

Introduction

The Chicago Transit Authority is the nation's second largest transit agency, transporting nearly one million passengers on an average weekday — the majority of whom ride the bus, not the “L” elevated rail lines. The passage of Senate Bill 2111 in late 2025 unlocked an estimated $1.209 billion in new operating revenue for the region and fundamentally restructured how transit is governed. For the first time in decades, the CTA has both the financial foundation and the institutional mandate to be ambitious about its bus network. Western Avenue BRT is the most compelling project in support of that mandate — a high-ridership corridor with near-unanimous aldermanic support, a street wide enough for dedicated lanes, and the potential to connect some of Chicago's most transit-dependent communities to a faster, more reliable network.

Yet the failure of the Ashland Avenue BRT in the mid-2010s demands that this opportunity be approached differently. Ashland was shelved not for lack of merit, but because organized opposition drowned out the riders who stood to benefit most. Research on BRT politics tells us this is not a Chicago anomaly. It is a structural problem, and favorable conditions alone cannot overcome it. This report, prepared for the CTA, proposes a public engagement framework designed to build the broad and durable coalition that the Western Avenue BRT needs to reach the finish line.

The Chicago Transit Authority and Its Regional Context

A Brief Overview of the CTA

The Chicago Transit Authority was formed in the post-World War II era in response to the financial troubles of privately held rapid transit and streetcar companies. In its current state, the CTA operates a system of 127 bus routes and 8 heavy rail lines — popularly referred to as the L — with 10,588 and 146 stops respectively. Together, the system transports nearly one million passengers on an average weekday, making the CTA the nation's second largest transit agency (Chicago Transit Authority CTA facts at a glance, 2025).

While the L is the backbone of the system and moves a large number of people into and out of the central business district, a majority of the system's ridership is generated by the bus network. Buses provide crucial connections between neighborhoods and to the rail system — with 96% of Chicago residents living within half a mile of a bus stop. Despite this, the bus network has historically taken a back seat to rail in planning and public discourse — a dynamic the CTA's Bus Vision Study, discussed further in this report, aims to reorient (Chicago Transit Authority Bus Vision Project, 2023).

The CTA is the largest component of the wider transportation system supporting the Chicago Metro Area. Metra provides commuter rail service on track largely leased from freight companies, and Pace operates suburban buses in communities primarily outside of Cook County. Together, these three agencies form the regional transit network that the Regional Transportation Authority (RTA) was established in 1974 to coordinate and fund (Regional Transportation Authority, n.d.).

A Region in Transition: Senate Bill 2111 and the Creation of NITA

By the early 2020s, the framework enabling the RTA and its constituent agencies was under severe strain. The expiration of COVID relief funds created a looming funding cliff that threatened service cuts across the region. The CTA's 2026 budget was finalized before any rescue legislation was confirmed, and presented three scenarios: a baseline, a growth budget outlining service expansions, and a reduced budget reflecting the cuts that would be required without new funding (Chicago Transit Authority FY26 Budget, 2025).

The passage and signing of Senate Bill 2111, a landmark funding bill, in late 2025 avoids the reduced budget scenario. In addition, the RTA will be dissolved and replaced by the Northern Illinois Transit Authority (NITA) in mid-2026. The bill allows the generation of an estimated $1.209 billion in new operating revenue, coming from an increase in state gas tax and a sales tax increase in NITA's service area. Additional capital funding estimated around $180 million will come from interest collected on the state road and construction fund. In administering this funding, NITA is granted significant oversight and authority, including the ability to set fare policy, develop a consolidated fare collection system, enforce year-over-year financial efficiency across agencies, and ensure the establishment of mandatory initiatives such as a regional police force (Regional Transportation Authority NITA Act summary and timeline, 2026).

Central to NITA's governance is a board that will comprise 20 directors: 5 appointed by the Mayor of Chicago, 5 by the Governor, 5 by the President of the Cook County Board, and 5 by collar county chairs, each subject to approval by their respective governing bodies. Notably, many of these directors will simultaneously serve on the boards of CTA, Metra, and Pace,

creating direct links between NITA and the agencies it oversees. This restructuring also reshapes the CTA's own board. Under the current structure, the CTA's seven-member board draws from four mayoral and three gubernatorial appointees. NITA's legislation restructures this to include two Cook County Board appointments, with the Mayor retaining three seats and the Governor two, with several members cross-appointed to the NITA board (Regional Transportation Authority NITA Act summary and timeline, 2026).

Under the RTA, the CTA was required to maintain a system-generated revenue recovery ratio of 42%; failure to do so prevents the RTA from "[passing] a regional transit budget, which could delay critical operations funding" (Regional Transportation Authority, 2025). This threshold was met in 2025 at 47.95%, though the RTA itself acknowledged the requirement as unnecessarily punitive and rare among peer agencies. NITA addresses this by waiving the requirement entirely in 2026, reducing it to 25% from 2027 through 2029, and dropping it further to 20% thereafter.

The CTA's Budget and Capital Program in the NITA Era

The CTA's 2026 budget totals approximately $2.1 billion in operating expenses. On the revenue side, the agency remains heavily dependent on public funding — primarily sales tax receipts — accounting for roughly $1.38 billion, while system-generated revenue including fares contributes $464 million (Chicago Transit Authority FY26 Budget, 2025). Notably, the budget still draws on $257 million in relief and reserve funds, a figure that drops to zero by 2027 as the agency transitions to a post-COVID funding baseline under NITA.

The CTA's 2026-2030 Capital Improvement Program (CIP) totals approximately $6.75 billion, organized around four core priorities: safety and reliability, accessibility, equity, and regulatory compliance. The dominant investment by far is the Red Line Extension at roughly $3.8 billion, which alone accounts for over half the program's total cost. Beyond that project, the CIP allocates significant funding toward rail and bus rolling stock, the All Station Accessibility Program, and ongoing security and communications upgrades. Bus and rail fleet renewal together account for approximately $994 million. While the Red Line Extension dominates the CIP, the bus network — which carries the majority of the system's ridership — remains a critical area of investment need, and one where new funding creates room for ambition (Chicago Transit Authority FY26 Budget, 2025).

A Case for the Western Avenue BRT

The Bus Vision Project: A Diagnosis and Direction for the Bus Network

The CTA's Bus Vision Study is a comprehensive and ongoing review of the bus network, examining structural issues and whether service patterns are appropriate for modern travel patterns. The study emerges from a prolonged period of decline where service levels have been suppressed since major cuts in 2010, compounded by staffing shortages and the COVID-19 pandemic, all of which have eroded ridership and reliability over the past fifteen years (Chicago Transit Authority Bus Vision Project, 2023).

The study identifies several structural factors that make improving bus service difficult: slow boarding times, closely spaced stops, a lack of dedicated right-of-way, and the tendency of the highest-ridership routes to operate over long distances where delays compound and

cascade. Given the constrained funding landscape at the time of the report, recommendations centered largely on maximizing the existing frequent bus grid, including collaborating with the city to improve streets for buses, adjusting stop spacing, and implementing physical stop improvements such as bump-outs. An early deliverable of the study was achieved at the end of 2025, with 10-minute all-day frequencies established on 20 routes across the system.

With NITA now providing a stable and significantly expanded funding base, the Bus Vision Study serves as a critical policy framework for evaluating how the CTA can more ambitiously address the structural challenges of its bus network. A key initiative in the growth budget — and one now funded by NITA — is increased bus service, route extensions, and connections, totaling approximately $200 million in investment. It is within this context that Western Avenue emerges as a priority corridor.

Western Avenue Should be a Priority Corridor

Western Avenue is one of Chicago's most significant north-south arterials, stretching the length of the city. The proposed BRT corridor would be scoped from 79th Street on the South Side to Berwyn Avenue on the North Side, a stretch where the existing Route 49 Western bus carries millions of riders annually, with ridership consistently ranking among the top routes in the system. The corridor was studied alongside Ashland Avenue as a BRT candidate during the early 2010s alternatives analysis, and has re-emerged as an option following the shelving of the Ashland project (Chicago Transit Authority & Chicago Department of Transportation, 2013).

BRT would bring dedicated lanes to a corridor that currently operates in mixed traffic, directly addressing the challenges identified by the Bus Vision Study. NITA's funding legislation provides the CTA with the financial foundation to pursue ambitious bus investments, including increased service, route extensions, and connections. Additionally, 17 of 18 aldermanic offices along the route have already signed a letter of support, reflecting a level of political alignment that is rare for a project of this scale (40th Ward of Chicago, 2024).

The conditions are better than they have ever been, but as the following section demonstrates, favorable conditions are not a substitute for a deliberate engagement strategy. The failure of the Ashland Avenue BRT, a project with equally compelling evidence behind it, is a reminder that the political dynamics of BRT do not disappear simply because the climate is friendlier.

Why Good BRT Projects Fail: Lessons from Ashland Avenue

Ashland Avenue BRT was a Project with Promise

The Ashland Avenue BRT began as a promising project, seeking to reduce travel times along one of the city's busiest bus corridors on a wide, 70-foot curb-to-curb street that could connect riders across the North, West, and South sides without routing through the Loop. The numbers were compelling. Ashland carried 10 million boardings in 2012, making it one of the highest ridership bus routes in the system. A dedicated center-running BRT lane would have saved commuters up to 65 hours per year, with speeds comparable to the Red Line. The environmental assessment found no significant impacts, and the CTA and CDOT conducted extensive community engagement throughout the alternatives analysis process (Chicago

Transit Authority & Chicago Department of Transportation, 2013). By most measures, the Ashland Avenue BRT was a well-evidenced, well-designed project with a clear public benefit.

How Ashland Avenue BRT Failed

The project's demise came from a well-organized opposition effort led primarily by business owners along the corridor, who successfully co-opted aldermanic support and, critically, the backing of progressive mayoral challenger Jesus "Chuy" Garcia. Once his difficult primary victory secured reelection, Mayor Rahm Emanuel had little appetite to continue the fight. What made this outcome particularly damaging was not just the strength of the opposition, but the absence of an equally organized constituency on the other side. While the CTA conducted community engagement that informed the project's design, that process did not translate into an organized rider constituency capable of matching the political mobilization of business opposition. Notably, the leading opposition group rebranded their resistance as the "Modern Express Bus" proposal, framing themselves as pro-transit reformers rather than opponents. This rhetorical move muddied the public debate and made the opposition harder to confront directly (Spielman, 2015; Ashland-Western Coalition, n.d.).

The CTA's outreach was extensive, with dozens of community organization meetings, aldermanic briefings, and direct ridership outreach across the corridor. A closer look at the geographic and organizational distribution of that engagement reveals a more complicated picture. Business associations were well represented. Direct ridership outreach was concentrated at L stations, not at the intermediate bus stops where the corridor's most transit-dependent riders actually board. The people transferring from bus to L are not the same people riding the bus end to end. The process produced informed participants but not an

organized constituency, and when political opposition mobilized, there was no equivalent counter-mobilization from the rider community.

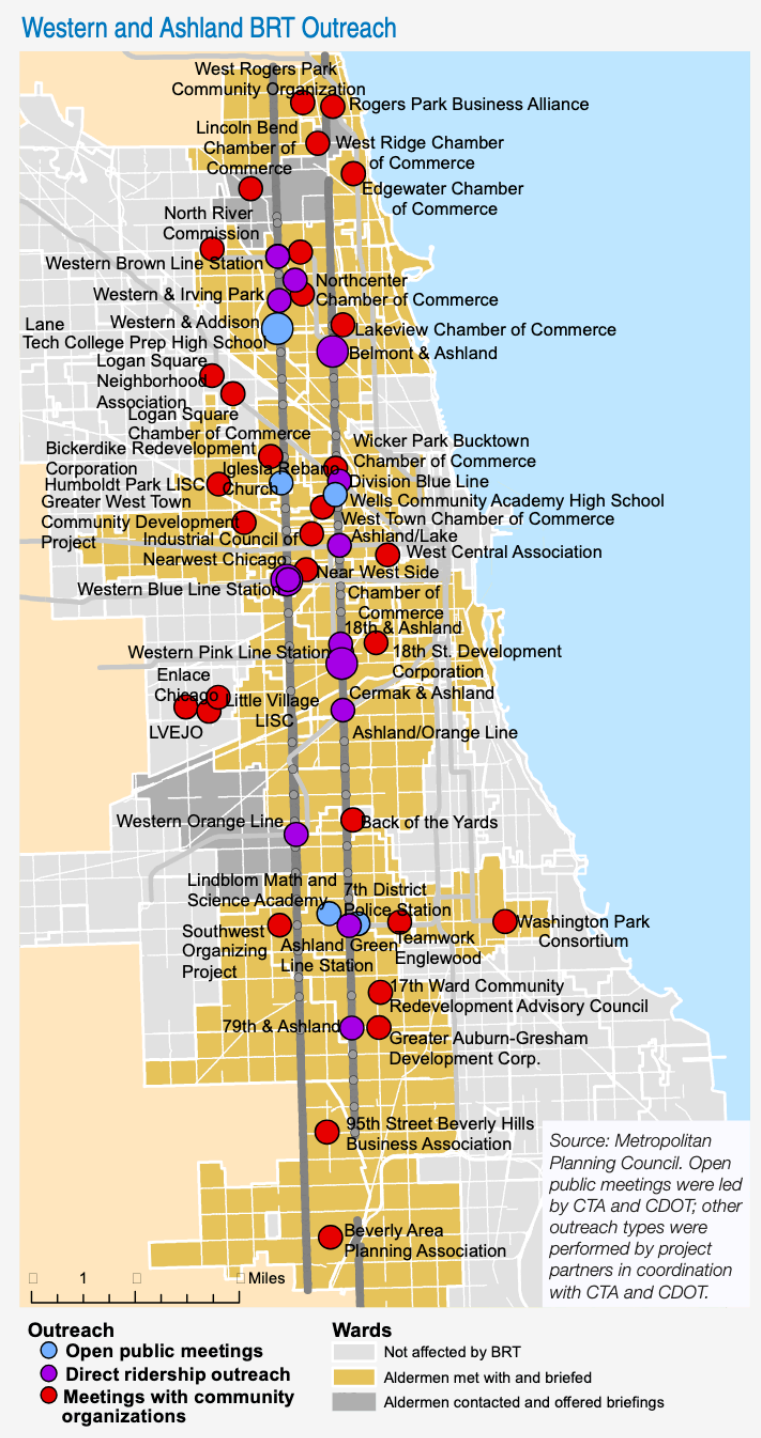


Figure 1: Western and Ashland Ave BRT Outreach in 2012 (Source: CTA Alternatives Analysis)

A Structural Problem, Not Bad Luck

The failure of the Ashland Avenue BRT was not a Chicago anomaly. Research on BRT politics tells us this pattern repeats itself because BRT projects face a structural political disadvantage. Goedeking (2023) argues that the benefits of BRT are broadly distributed among urban residents, generating support that is "relatively broad but shallow." The costs, on the other hand, are concentrated among a handful of interest groups including business owners and car-dependent residents, generating opposition that is "narrow but deep." When broad but shallow support competes with narrow but deep opposition, the supporting coalition faces a structural disadvantage. Those with something to lose get activated. Those with something to gain often do not.

This dynamic was compounded on Ashland by the nature of the project itself. Sukaryavichute and Prytherch (2018) argue that proposals to reallocate street space prompt complex politics of mobility, pitting advocates for alternative modes against those vested in vehicular travel, parking, and the businesses who value them. When planners framed Ashland BRT as a challenge to traditional assumptions about what streets are for, those vested in vehicular mobility took up that challenge, resulting in what the authors describe as "effective maintenance of status quo on Ashland Avenue."

Western Avenue Faces the Same Crosswinds

Western Avenue BRT faces the same structural political dynamics that shelved the Ashland Avenue BRT, and favorable conditions alone do not change this calculus.

It is worth acknowledging that the environment is meaningfully better than it was in the early 2010s. NITA has resolved the funding crisis, 17 of 18 aldermanic offices along the route have signaled support, the public discourse around transit investment has shifted, and Chicago's transit advocacy infrastructure is stronger than it was when Ashland was shelved.

Western Avenue is nonetheless a long corridor traversing dramatically different communities, with business districts, street parking, and car-dependent residents concentrated in its northern segments. BRT is inherently countercultural — it reallocates street space from one set of users to another, creating tangible losses for some in order to deliver gains for many. Addressing that reality requires more than political will. It requires a deliberate effort to engage those who stand to lose as legitimate stakeholders, while simultaneously building a deeper and more organized constituency among the communities that stand to gain the most. That is the task this report's engagement framework is designed to address.

An Engagement Framework for the Western Avenue BRT

Stakeholder Mapping

Before outreach begins, the CTA should develop a data-driven equity profile of the corridor drawing on census tract-level data on transit dependency, income, and demographic composition to identify communities with the highest stake in the project and the greatest history of exclusion from planning. As discussed in the preceding section, BRT projects face a structural political disadvantage that makes stakeholder mapping not just good practice but a strategic necessity. The stakeholder map should distinguish between those with the most to gain, those most likely to organize in opposition, and institutions including CDOT, aldermanic

offices, and community organizations who can help build a coalition deep enough to withstand that opposition.

Community Outreach

The CTA should embed engagement into community life rather than creating events that compete for residents' time and attention. This means showing up at church gatherings, weekend business crawls, school events, and neighborhood association meetings rather than asking residents to attend yet another planning meeting. This approach, informed by the practice of organizations like the Kensington Corridor Trust in Philadelphia, signals genuine investment rather than a transactional request (S. Kakumanu, personal communication, 2025). On-bus rider surveys on the existing Route 49 Western bus are the most direct approach, reaching current users without requiring any additional commitment. Where new engagement events are warranted, the block party model offers a low-barrier format that can be hosted directly on Western Avenue (Hinge Collective, 2024).

Design Input and Visualization

Design input should extend the same philosophy of meeting people where they are. Pop-up engagement at existing Route 49 stops can provide input on stop placement, station amenities, safety, and L and Metra connections based on riders' lived experiences. Augmented reality visualization can complement this process. During engagement for its West Broad Street BRT project, Columbus's COTA used an AR app to let residents walk through renderings of proposed stations at the actual sites where they would be built (Vugrincic, 2024). Deploying a similar tool at key stops along Western Avenue would let riders see what BRT would look like at

their corner, and empower them to provide meaningful feedback before opposition fills the vacuum with fear of an unfamiliar proposal. Offering participation options ranging from comment cards to formal working group membership ensures design input reflects a broad cross-section of the corridor (Hinge Collective, 2024).

Accountability and Ongoing Engagement

A Community Advisory Committee weighted toward South and West Side corridor residents should remain active through design, procurement, and construction. The CTA should transparently document how community input shaped decisions, and where it did not, to maintain trust and preserve the project's political mandate through to completion.

The Western Ave Corridor: Demographics & Stakeholder Typology

Corridor Demographics and Transit Dependency

Understanding who lives and travels along the Western Avenue corridor is the foundation of an effective stakeholder mapping process. The three figures that follow profile the Western Avenue BRT corridor from 79th Street to Berwyn Avenue using American Community Survey five-year estimates at the census tract level, aggregated to a one-kilometer hexagonal grid. Taken together, they reveal a corridor traversing communities of immense socioeconomic diversity. Median household income varies dramatically from the corridor's northern terminus to its southern end. The percent of people of color follows a near-inverse pattern, with the corridor segments in southern and western Chicago home to the highest concentrations of Black and Latino residents. Zero-car household rates spike in similar segments. These patterns identify the southern and western segments of the corridor as the

areas of highest transit need and the greatest imperative for proactive, equity-centered engagement.

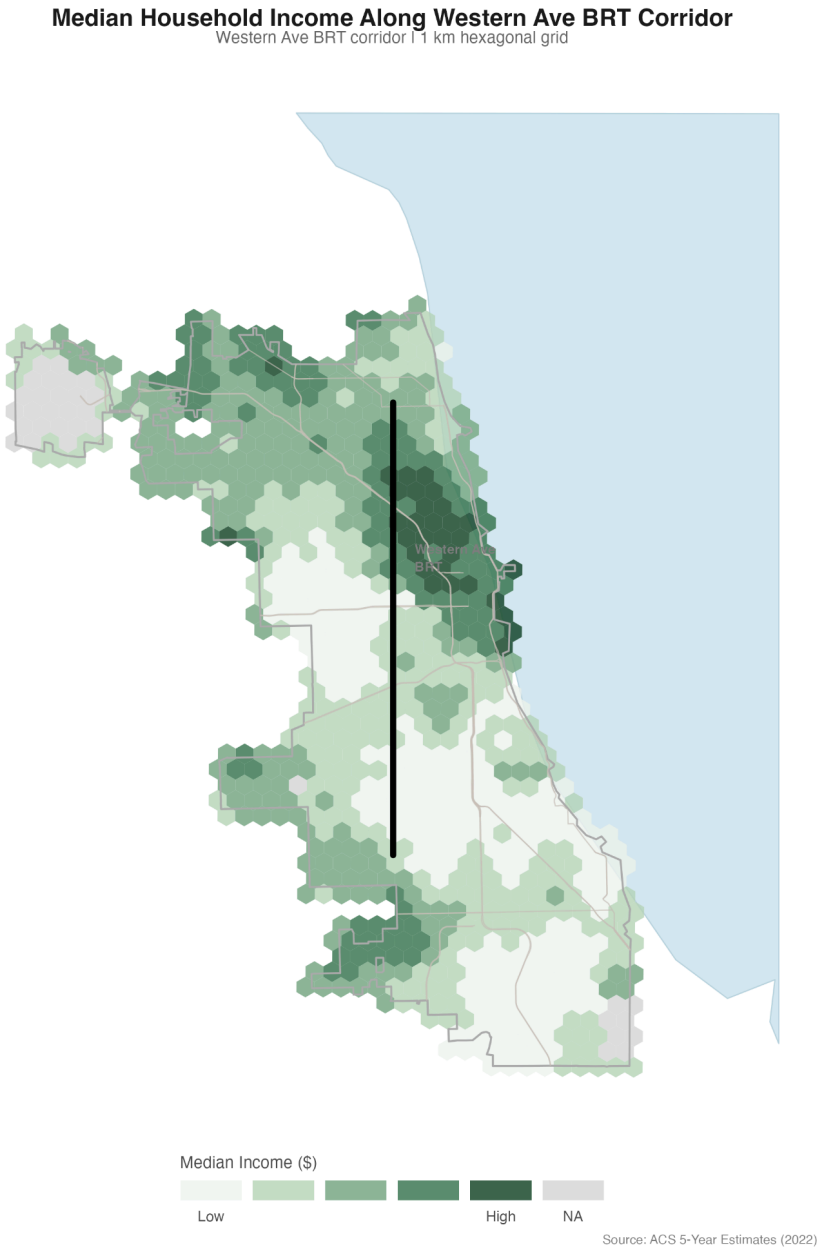


Figure 2: Median Household Incomes in Chicago, Western Ave BRT in Black

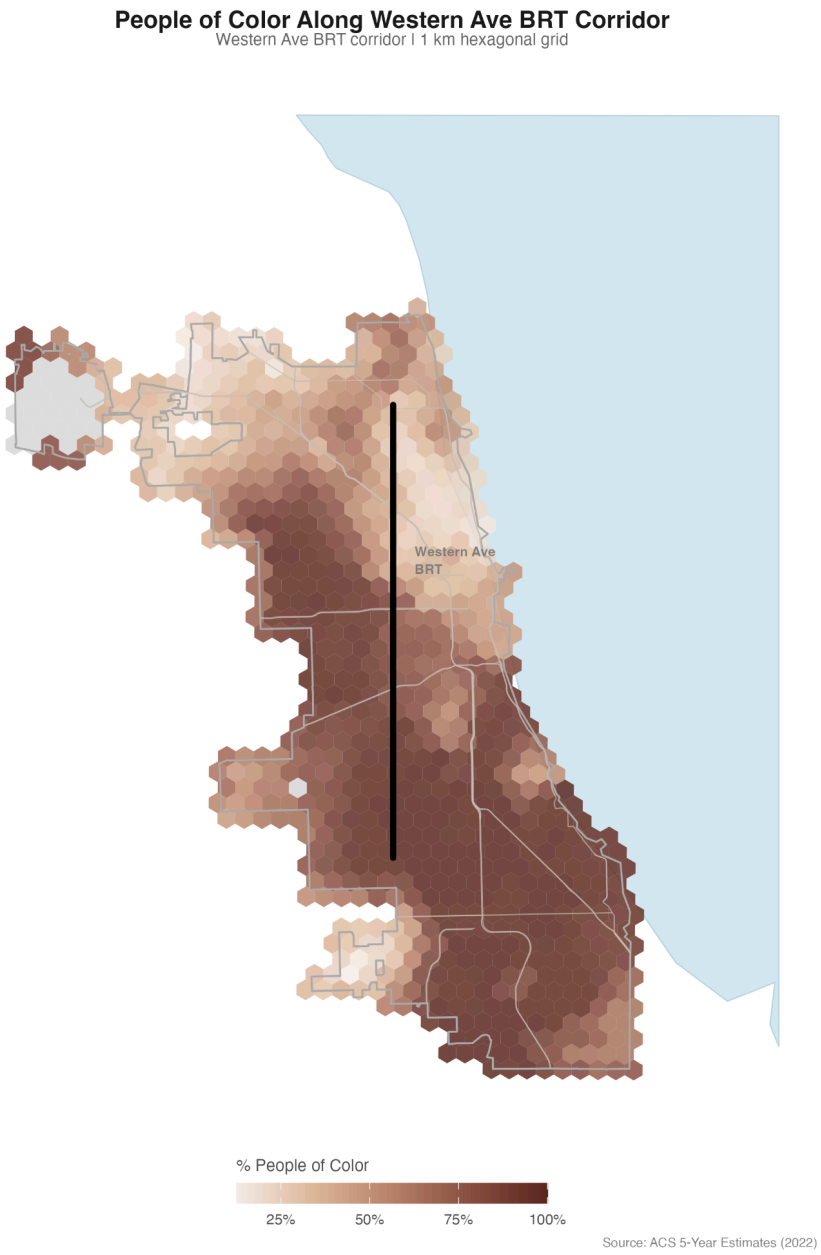


Figure 3: % People of Color in Chicago, Western Ave BRT in Black

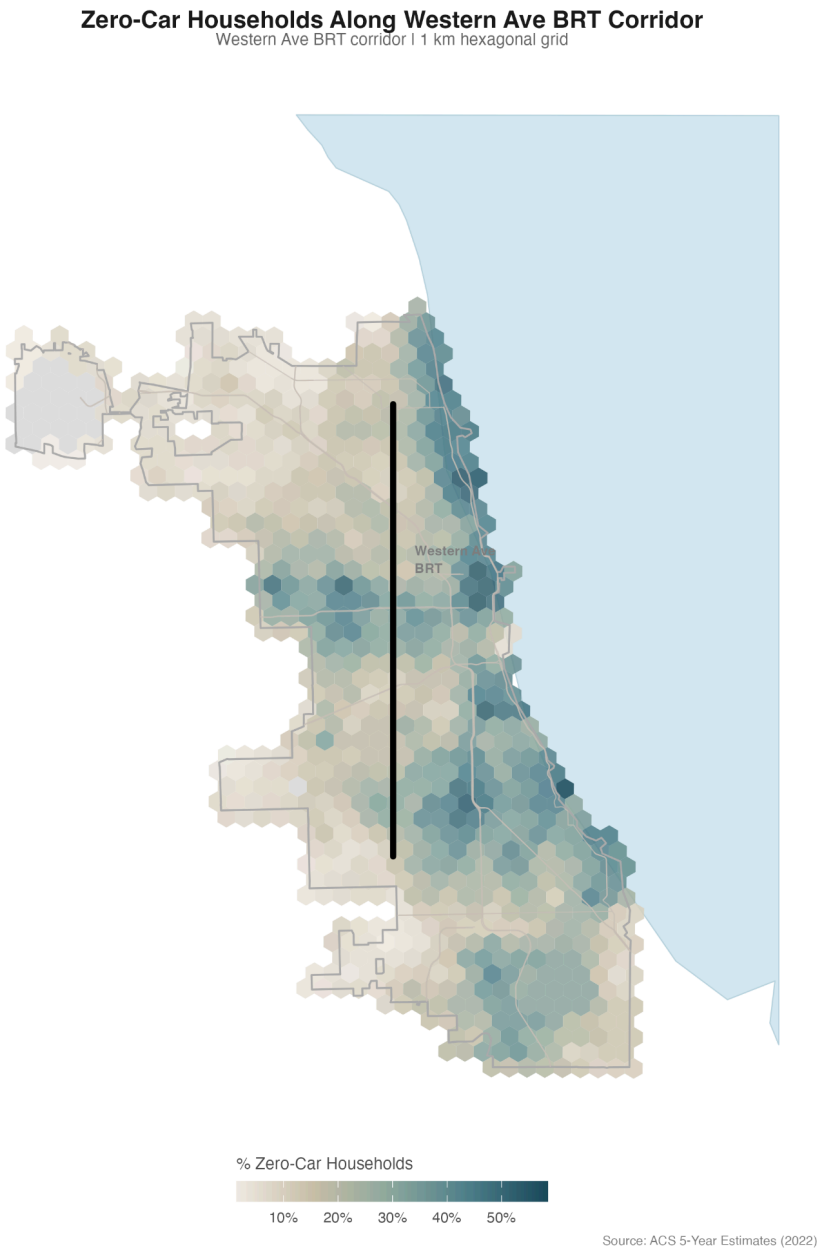


Figure 4: % Zero-Car Households in Chicago, Western Ave BRT in Black

A Stakeholder Typology for Western Avenue

Demographic data alone does not tell us who will show up, who will stay quiet, and who will organize. To guide the stakeholder mapping process, it is useful to classify corridor stakeholders along two dimensions: their stake in the project's outcomes and their likely level of engagement in the planning process. This produces four categories: those with a high stake and high voice, those with a high stake and low voice, those with a low stake and high voice, and those with a low stake and low voice.

The high stake, high voice quadrant includes organized transit advocates, aldermanic offices, and community organizations with existing civic infrastructure — groups that are already engaged and likely to participate without proactive outreach. The high stake, low voice quadrant is the most critical and the most underserved in traditional planning processes. These are transit-dependent residents in the southern and western segments of the corridor — communities identified in the preceding figures as having the lowest incomes, the highest concentrations of people of color, and the highest rates of zero-car households. These residents have the most to gain from Western Avenue BRT and are the least likely to show up at a formal planning meeting. The low stake, high voice quadrant includes business associations and car-dependent residents concentrated in the corridor's northern segments — groups whose opposition to BRT, as the Ashland case demonstrates, can be disproportionately loud relative to their stake in the project's outcomes. The low stake, low voice quadrant includes occasional riders and residents with limited connection to the corridor.

Hinge Collective's engagement guidance identifies a similar typology in practice, distinguishing between community organizations, community leaders such as faith leaders and

block captains, and broader stakeholders including nearby residents and interest groups (Hinge Collective, 2024). Critically, the guidance notes that existing community organizations should be used to reach audiences that may otherwise be hard to reach or distrustful of the process, and that community members and organizations should be compensated for their participation to build capacity rather than drain resources (Hinge Collective, 2024). For Western Avenue, this means the CTA's engagement effort should be deliberately weighted toward the high stake, low voice quadrant. Critically, this is not because other voices do not matter, but because that quadrant represents both the greatest need and the greatest gap in traditional outreach approaches.

From Framework to Action

A Phased Engagement Timeline

The engagement framework proposed in this report should be a continuous process that is tied to the project's development milestones. A phased approach ensures that the coalition being built does not dissipate between planning and construction, and that the CTA remains accountable to corridor communities at every stage of the project's development. This approach can be put into action as follows:

> **Pre-design:** Complete the stakeholder mapping, establish formal community organization partnerships, and begin embedding outreach into existing community spaces along the corridor.

Design development: Deploy pop-up engagement at existing Route 49 stops and augmented reality visualization, convene the working group, and hold the first Community Advisory Committee meeting.

Design completion through procurement: Maintain the Advisory Committee, begin publicly documenting how community input shaped design decisions, and sustain coalition communication.

Construction through opening: Continue Advisory Committee monitoring, provide regular community updates on timelines and disruptions, and frame the groundbreaking as a coalition milestone.

Measuring Success

The success of this engagement framework should be measured by the quality and representativeness of the process itself. Key metrics include the demographic breakdown of participants relative to the corridor population, the number of community organizations formally partnered with, the geographic distribution of outreach events across corridor segments, and the composition and attendance of the Community Advisory Committee. This will provide an ongoing signal of whether the coalition being built is genuinely broad and deep or merely broad on paper.

Conclusion

The Western Avenue BRT arrives at a moment of genuine opportunity. The passage of NITA has resolved the funding crisis that constrained the CTA's ambitions for over a decade,

the Bus Vision Study has diagnosed the structural challenges facing the bus network, and 17 of 18 aldermanic offices along the corridor have already signaled their support. The conditions are better than they have ever been.

Ashland had compelling evidence behind it too, and it was shelved anyway. The structural dynamics of BRT politics do not disappear because the climate is friendlier. Concentrated opposition can organize, and without a broad, deep, and organized rider constituency to counter it, the same outcome is possible.

What the Western Avenue BRT needs is an engagement process that supports this opportunity. One that centers the communities with the most to gain, builds a constituency capable of sustaining the project through opposition, and treats public engagement not as a procedural requirement but as the foundation of the project's legitimacy.

References

40th Ward of Chicago. (2024, May). Letter calling for BRT on Western Avenue. Retrieved from https://40thward.org/2024/05/letter-calling-for-bus-rapid-transit-on-western-avenue/

Ashland-Western Coalition. (n.d.). Save Ashland. Retrieved from http://www.saveashland.com/

Chicago Transit Authority. (2025). CTA facts at a glance. Retrieved from https://www.transitchicago.com/facts/

Chicago Transit Authority. (2025). FY2026 budget book. Retrieved from https://www.transitchicago.com/assets/1/6/FY2026_Budget_Book.pdf

Chicago Transit Authority & Chicago Department of Transportation. (2013). Western and Ashland corridors bus rapid transit project: Alternatives analysis summary. Prepared by CDM Smith. Retrieved from https://www.transitchicago.com/assets/1/6/RP_CDMSMith_BS_Screen2MagFINAL_20131205_reduced.pdf

Chicago Transit Authority Bus Vision Project. (2023). Chicago framing report. Retrieved from https://ctabusvisionproject.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/Chicago-Framing-Report_Final_Dec2023_rev.pdf

Goedeking, N. (2023). Broad support vs. deep opposition: The politics of bus rapid transit in low- and middle-income countries. Transport Policy, 138, 1–12. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tranpol.2023.10.019

Hinge Collective. (2024). Block party guide. Retrieved from https://hinge-collective.com/resources/#hingeguides

Hinge Collective. (2024). Engagement essentials. Retrieved from https://hinge-collective.com/resources/#hingeguides

Regional Transportation Authority. (n.d.). About RTA. Retrieved from https://www.rtachicago.org/about-rta

Regional Transportation Authority. (n.d.). Transit funding. Retrieved from https://www.rtachicago.org/transit-funding

Regional Transportation Authority. (2025, October 9). Illinois transit farebox recovery ratio requirement is uniquely high and harms riders. Retrieved from

https://www.rtachicago.org/blog/2025/10/09/illinois-transit-farebox-recovery-ratio-requirement-is-uniquely-high-and-harms-riders

Regional Transportation Authority. (2026). NITA Act summary and timeline. Retrieved from https://www.rtachicago.org/uploads/files/meeting-materials/Board-Meetings/2026/January/6a_NITA_Act_Summary_and_Timeline.pdf

Spielman, F. (2015, August 18). Ashland BRT seems all but dead with return of Ashland-Western express buses. Chicago Sun-Times. Retrieved from https://chicago.suntimes.com/2015/8/18/18450429/ashland-brt-seems-all-but-dead-with-return-of-ashland-western-express-buses

Sukaryavichute, E., & Prytherch, D. L. (2018). Transit planning, access, and justice: Evolving visions of bus rapid transit and the Chicago street. Journal of Transport Geography, 69, 49–63. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jtrangeo.2018.04.007

Vugrincic, A. (2024, May 10). Augmented reality introduces COTA's rapid bus transit vision for West Broad Street. WOSU Public Media. Retrieved from https://www.wosu.org/2024-05-10/augmented-reality-introduces-cotas-rapid-bus-transit-vision-for-west-broad-street